

Swaziland



The tiny southern African kingdom of Swaziland is crippled with HIV/AIDS and economically dependent on South Africa. Vocal demands for multiparty democracy have been ignored.



GEOGRAPHY

Mainly high plateaus and mountains. Rolling grasslands and low scrub plains to the east. Pine forests on western border.



CLIMATE

Temperatures rise and rainfall declines as the land descends eastward, from high to low grassy *veld*.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

One of Africa's most conservative states, though there is pressure from urban-based modernizers. Political system promotes Swazi tradition and is dominated by powerful monarchy. Women face discrimination. Swaziland has world's highest prevalence of HIV/AIDS: chastity is urged to combat its spread.



INSIGHT: Polygamy is practiced in Swaziland – when King Sobhuza died in 1982, he left 100 widows



THE ECONOMY

Sugarcane is the main cash crop. Wood pulp and soft drink concentrates are also exported. Loss of workforce to HIV/AIDS, and high cost of health care.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of Swaziland

DATE OF FORMATION: 1968

CAPITAL: Mbabane

POPULATION: 1.18 million

TOTAL AREA: 6704 sq. miles
(17,363 sq. km)

DENSITY: 178 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, siSwati*, isiZulu, Xitsonga

RELIGIONS: Christian 60%, traditional beliefs 40%

ETHNIC MIX: Swazi 97%, other 3%

GOVERNMENT: Monarchy

CURRENCY: Lilangeni = 100 cents